

5 WAYS TO IMPROVE YOUR PUBLIC SPEAKING



MASTERING COMMUNICATION

Whether you're preparing for a boardroom presentation, a pitch to a potential client or any meeting, the way you communicate your message will significantly impact your audience and, in doing that, your chances of achieving the outcome you're looking for.

The good news for those who aren't natural public speakers is that the skills of public speaking can be learnt and improved with the right approach and mindset and, through practice.

The goal is to speak in any setting with **clarity**, **confidence**, and **impact**, to be remembered and, to use the opportunity to build your personal credibility.

So, let's dive into five practical tips to help you **enhance your public speaking skills**, ensuring that your next presentation is not just heard, but remembered and achieves the outcome you're looking for.



BE CLEAR ON YOUR OBJECTIVE AND WHO YOUR AUDIENCE IS

Understanding your objective:

Begin by asking yourself the purpose of your talk. Are you looking to inform, persuade, entertain, or inspire your audience? Your objective will guide the structure and content of your presentation, ensuring every element aligns with your end goal.

Knowing your audience:

Tailor your message to the interests, knowledge levels, communication style, and expectations of your listeners. Researching your audience beforehand can provide valuable insights into their background, allowing you to make your presentation more relatable and engaging. Be sure to run a web, LinkedIn, company website and general news search beforehand and if you have one, go back to company CRM records to find out as much useful information as you can find about the audience you'll meet. If your audience is internal, speak to those who know the key stakeholders well, asking for advice on what works and what doesn't work for the stakeholders.

Engagement strategy:

Consider incorporating interactive elements such as Q&A sessions, live polls (great for virtual presentations), or discussions to foster a connection with your audience and make your presentation more interactive. Encouraging individuals to put forward questions throughout the presentation, either through the chat function (if virtual) or by putting their hand up (if live) can help increase engagement as well.

If the group is small enough be sure to verbally check in regularly to ensure the audience is following you and use these check-ins as an opportunity to flush out questions and objections as they come up.



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REMEMBER THE POWER OF 3

Once you've defined your goal and understood your audience, the next step is to ensure clarity of your message(s). What are the key points you want your audience to remember?

Simplify complex ideas without diluting their essence. Each part of your presentation should contribute to the overall message you want to deliver.

Avoid overwhelming your audience with too much information. Instead, focus on 3 core messages and explore them fully. This approach not only makes it easier for your audience to follow along but also increases the likelihood that they will retain the information after the event.



The use of “signposting”, a verbal or visual marker indicating the direction you are taking or where you currently are, will help your audience move through the different concepts, connect the dots, and help them stay engaged.

For example, “when thinking about marketing budgets for 2024 there are 3 elements I’d like to discuss today, first, what we want to achieve in 2024, second, what we spent on marketing in 2023 and thirdly, any new areas of the business that require additional marketing spend in 2024”.

BRING THE MESSAGES TO LIFE

A memorable presentation is more than just words; it's an experience. Bring your messages to life through stories, analogies, data, graphics, and other visuals.

Stories can evoke strong emotions in their listeners, and that's exactly why emotional storytelling when presenting is so powerful. When you tell a story that resonates with your audience on an emotional level, it creates a deep connection between you and your audience, one that goes beyond just the facts and figures. If you get it right audience buy-in increases and hopefully with that, your credibility.

Data and graphics can be powerful tools to reinforce your arguments, providing a visual representation that enhances understanding and retention. When presenting data visually be sure to make life easy for your audience by putting the key message you want them to take away in the title. For example, rather than the title "Market Outlook" use instead, "Volatile Markets Create a Buying Opportunity". That simple title is all some people need; others will want to fully digest the data in the graphics shown.

The key is to use these elements judiciously. Each story, analogy, or visual should have a clear purpose and contribute to the overarching message of your presentation. This not only keeps your audience engaged but also helps to emphasize your key points, making your message more memorable and impactful.



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PERFECT THE BEGINNING AND THE END

The beginning and end of your presentation are crucial. The start sets the tone and, if done right, hooks your audience, drawing them into your narrative, building their anticipation for what will follow.



Crafting a captivating opening:

Utilize the ROW method (Reason, Order, What) to start strong. Begin by sharing the REASON why the topic is important, next outline the ORDER or structure of your talk (the agenda) and then, conclude your introduction by stating WHAT you aim to achieve. This should take no more than a minute to cover.

The power of first impressions:

The opening moments of your presentation are critical in capturing your audience's attention. What they decide about you in those opening moments will become the filter through which they listen to you (or not) as the presentation continues. Share a surprising fact, ask a rhetorical question, or tell a compelling story to make a strong first impression and capture their attention.

Concluding with impact:

Summarize the key points of your presentation and end with a call to action or a thought-provoking question. A memorable close can inspire your audience to reflect on your message, take specific action or engage in further dialogue with you.



REHEARSE, REHEARSE, REHEARSE



Rehearsing is perhaps the most crucial and yet, the most overlooked step in preparing for your presentation. It allows you to refine your timing, pace, and delivery.

Pay attention to your body language, making sure it conveys confidence and openness. Observe your eye contact, make sure you connect with your audience by looking them in the eye, making them feel involved and valued.

Practice your tone of voice to ensure its engaging, varying your pitch and volume to maintain interest.

Identify questions and objections in advance. Knowing how to address these confidently can enhance your credibility and the persuasiveness of your presentation. Have a plan in mind as to what you'll say if you don't know the answer – "That's a great question, I don't have that data to hand but I'll come back to you" is one way of responding.

Remember, effective public speaking is not just about delivering information; it's about making a connection with your audience. By focusing on these five areas and putting in the practice, you'll start to deliver presentations that are not only informative or persuasive, but also inspiring and memorable.



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